Southeast Asia. Beyond the religious-cultural linkages to others around it, India has a larger Asian identity arising out of migration, invasions, trade flows, philosophical thought, the arts, and even colonialism. The Indian diaspora in Asia and around the world also gives India a global cultural presence that perhaps only China can match. Politically, as the world's largest democracy, India shares values with modern Western civilization and other parts of the world. Geopolitically, India's non-alignment positions it as a bridge between the two Cold War blocs. Nehru makes the point that non-alignment is an active stance. It is not neutrality. India and other non-aligned countries are bound to intervene in the quarrels between the two blocs to help manage conflict in the interest of international peace and stability.[92] As the biggest of the non-aligned, India has a special responsibility: in a world torn between contending Great Powers, India's approach 'will continue to be not only to keep aloof from power alignments, but [also] try to make friendly co-operation possible'.[93]

The Nehruvian view of India as a pivotal, bridging Great Power is still widely shared in Indian strategic circles even if Nehru's policies are under increasing criticism. For instance, Modi's and Jaishankar's formulation of India as a 'leading power' has nothing Nehru would find troubling. Nehruvians are not naive about power, but they think that an international order based on an overly active striving for power must eventually collapse: the balance of power in Europe failed to prevent a world war twice in the twentieth century. Better than the striving for power is the pursuit of international cooperation. The Hindu right shares the Nehruvian belief in India as a potential Great Power. Yet its view of international order is suggestive of a different kind of pathway to power. M.S. Golwalkar, the second chief of the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS), articulates a Hindu nationalist view. He sees international order as inescapably one in which each state single-mindedly cultivates and pursues power: 'When we . . . read the world correctly, we are forced to arrive at the conclusion that the only basis for our free and prosperous national life is invincible national strength – a strength that will strike terror into the hearts of aggressive powers . . . Strength is the very elixir of national life.'[94] Nehru quietly